

Armenian Manuscripts and the Digital Age

Teaching the Codex III
Decentring the Codex

Merton College, Oxford
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Dr Robin Meyer

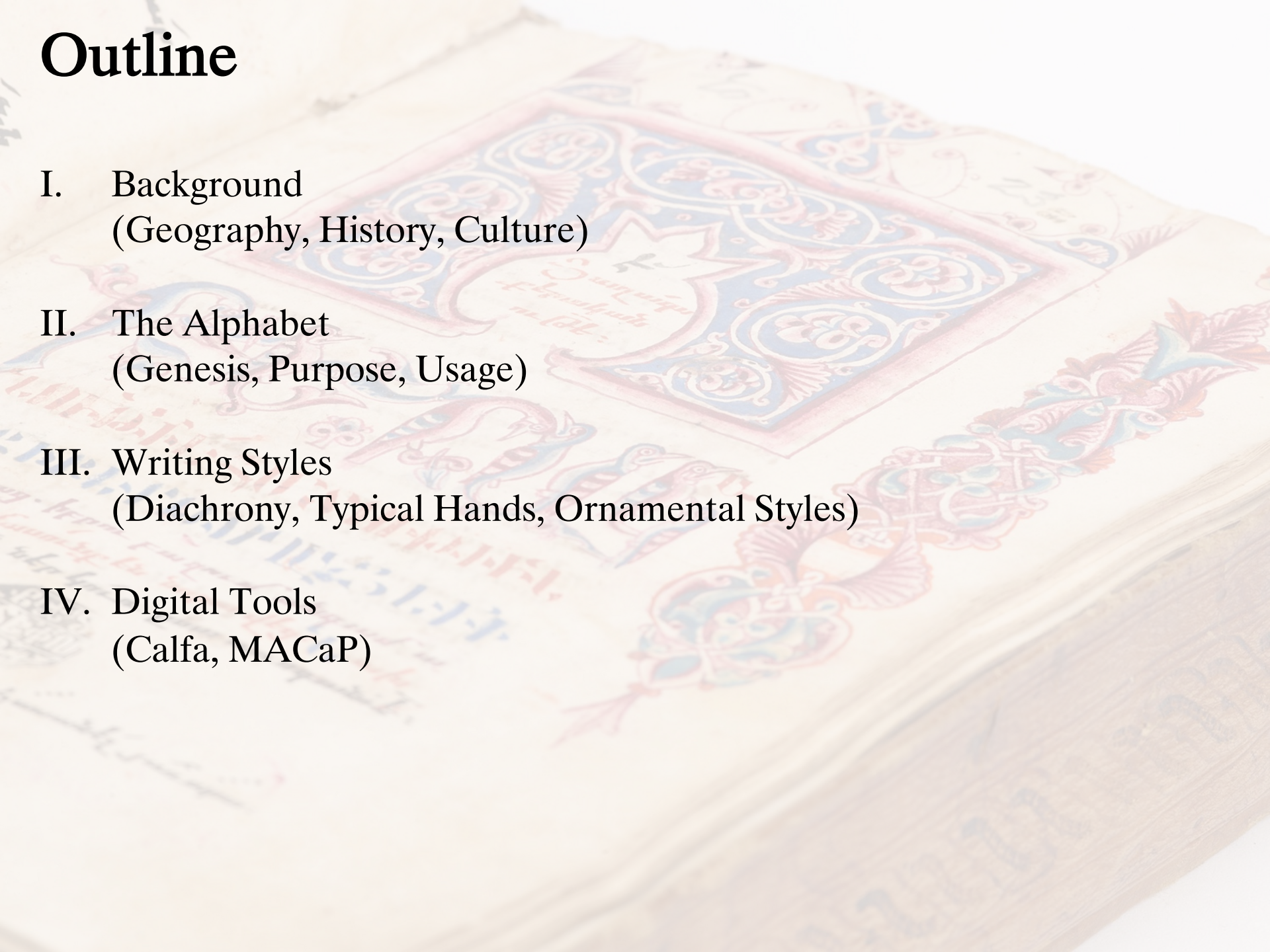
FACULTY OF
LINGUISTICS,
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PHONETICS

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robin.meyer@ling-phil.ox.ac.uk
www.rbnmyr.eu @rbnmyr



Outline



- I. Background
(Geography, History, Culture)
- II. The Alphabet
(Genesis, Purpose, Usage)
- III. Writing Styles
(Diachrony, Typical Hands, Ornamental Styles)
- IV. Digital Tools
(Calfa, MACaP)

Background I

- ‘Armina’ first attested in the royal inscription of Darius I at Behistun (late 6th century BCE)
- ruled for a millennium by Iranian dynasties (with short Armenian and Greek interludes)
- at its largest, Armenia encompassed parts of modern-day Turkey, Iran, Iraq, Syria, and even reached the Holy Land



Meyer (2017:7)

Background II

- the first state to adopt Christianity as its official religion in the early 4th century CE und King Trdat III (Tiridates the Great)
- first attested writing (according to historians!) in Armenian script dates to the 5th century CE; first manuscript: 862 CE (Queen Mlk'ē Gospel)
- earliest lapidary inscriptions (graffiti) found in Nazareth (!), date to the first half of the 5th century CE



Meyer (2017:9)

Background III



The Alphabet I

- after the Christianisation by St Grigor Lusaworič‘ (St Gregory the Illuminator), services were held in Greek or Syriac
- these languages were not accessible to the common people
- accordingly, Zoroastrianism—the prevalent religion until then—was still widespread
- translate Holy Scripture and the liturgy
- various attempts at using other writing systems had been made

‘And the king reported of a man, a certain Syrian bishop from a noble house, whose name was Daniēl, who had unexpectedly somehow had created letters for the alphabet of the Armenian language. [...] For two years [St Mesrop Maštoc‘] taught and used these letters; but [he] became aware that the signs were not sufficient to represent the syllables and sounds of the Armenian language.’

(Koriwn, *Life of Maštoc‘* §§33–42)

The Alphabet II

- created by the monk St Mesrop Maštoc' in c. 405 CE
- contains 36 (later 38) letters, written left-to-right
- suited ideally for the Armenian phonemic inventory with signs distinguishing voicing and aspiration (e.g. *դ* /d/ vs *տ* /t/ vs *թ* /t^h/) and providing for fricatives and affricates (e.g. *շ* /ʃ/ vs *ջ* /ʒ/)

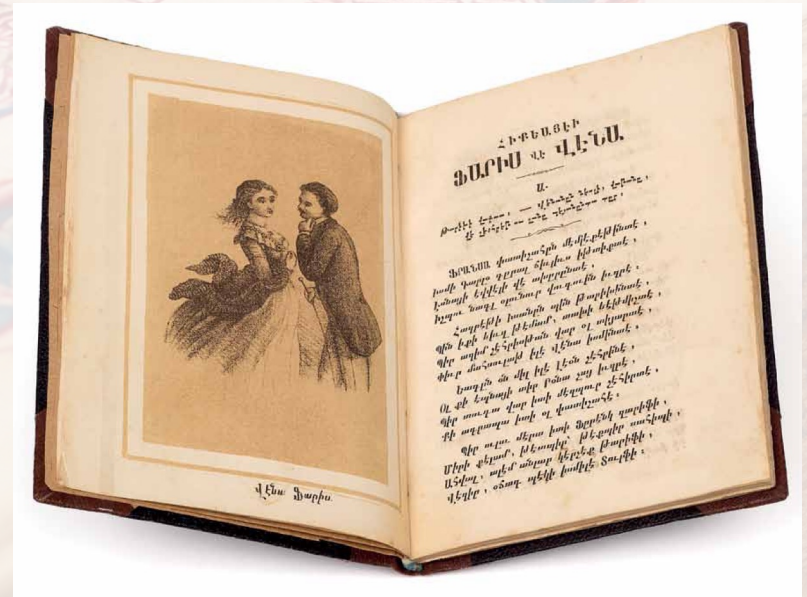
‘... and so the blessed Maštoc' took a group of youths [...] and in the fifth year of the Armenian king Vramšapuh [c. 405 CE] [...] reached two cities, Edessa and Amida by name. [...] He split his students into two groups: one for the the Syrian school [in Edessa], the other for the Greek school [in Amida]. [...] And indeed holy God granted him this luck, for by his right hand were brought forth new and wonderful offshoots of the Father's virility: signs for the Armenian language.’ (Koriwn, *Life of Maštoc'*, §§43–9)

The Alphabet III

- used throughout history to write Armenian (with only minor modifications)
- not only in Armenia proper, but also in diaspora communities in Turkey, India, France, the USA, etc.
- also used for other languages of the area, e.g. Turkish and Kurdish



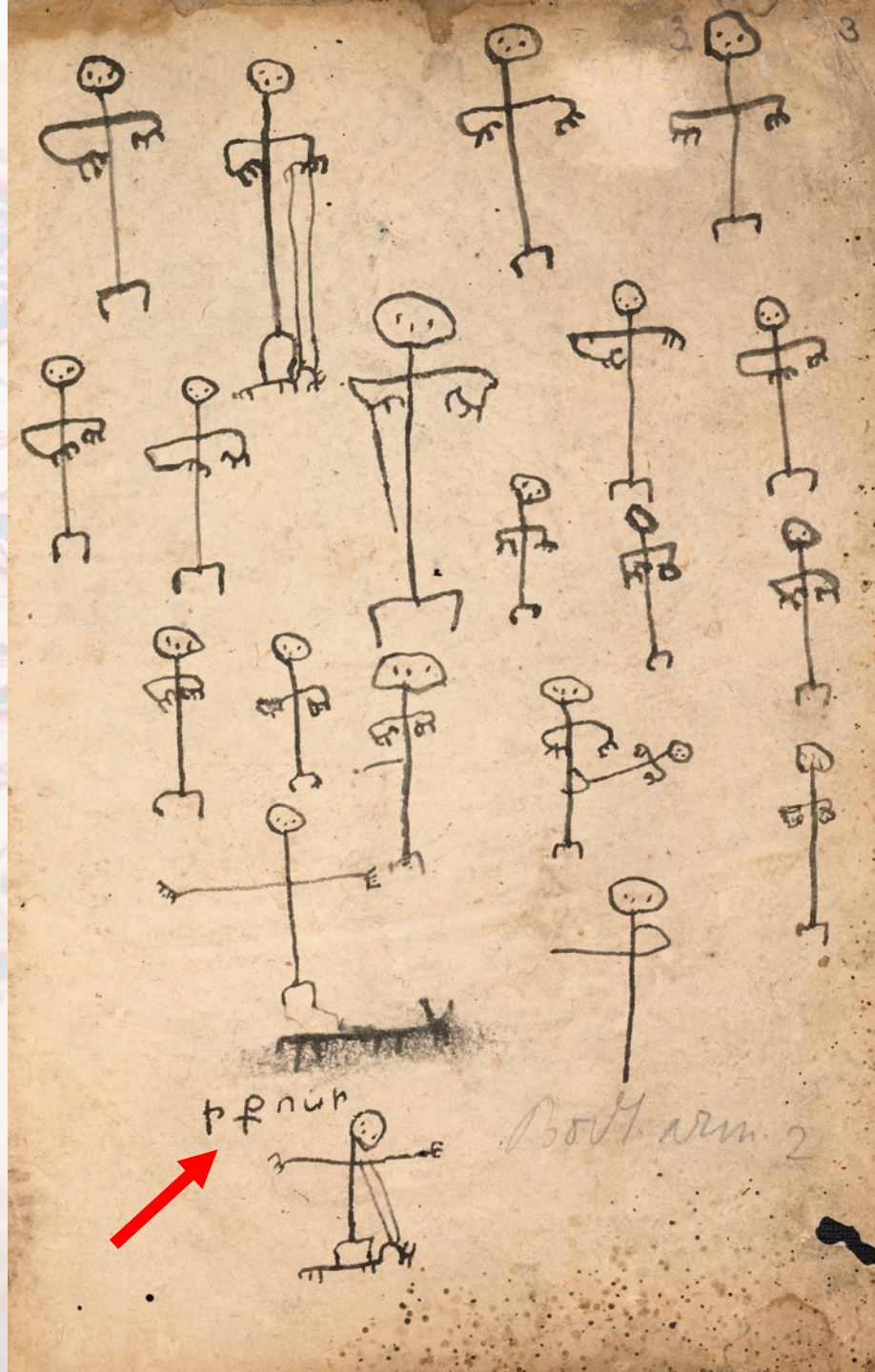
Last issue of *Haratch*, a Paris-based Armenian daily newspaper



Yeremya Çelebi Kömürçyan, *The Story of Paris and Vienne* (1650/60s). Ottoman Turkish in Armenian script (van Lint & Meyer 2015:161)

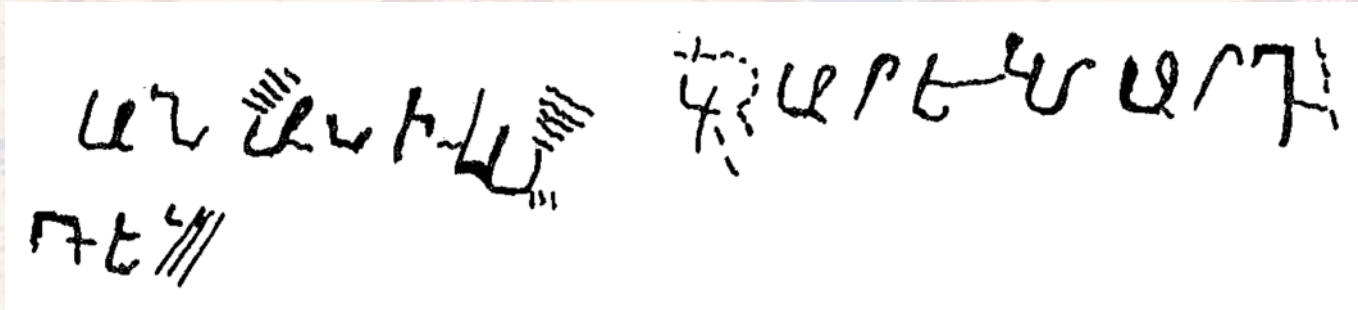
The Alphabet IV

- a page of doodles at the beginning of:
Bodleian MS Arm. d. 2
- the manuscript is a 13th-century lectionary
- the Armenian writing spells *ԻԲՈՍԻ* (ik'osi)
- that is the Greek word for 'twenty' (εἴκοσι)



The Alphabet V

- original uncials script, all letters are capitals
- so-called *երկաթագիր* (erkat‘agir) or ‘iron script’
- so attested in the inscriptions from Nazareth



Nazareth Arm 1 (Stone 1990–91:317)

- roughly: *ԱՆԱՆԻԱ ԱՐԵՄԱՐԴ*
ՌԵՆ

ANANIA AREMARD
REN

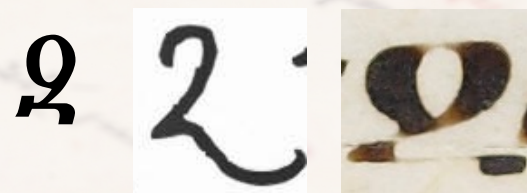
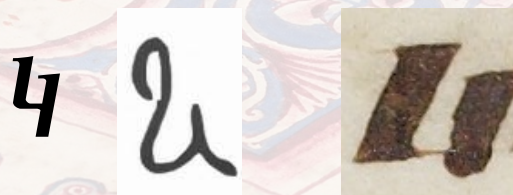
The Alphabet VI

- numerous correlations point to a Greek inspiration of the Armenian alphabet
 - the order of the letters in the *ալբուբեն* (*aybuben*) = alphabet
 - the writing of /u/ as a digraph *ու* (ow) like in Greek *ου*
 - letters have names:
 - ալբ* (ayb), *բեն* (ben), *գիմ* (gim), *դա* (da), *եչ* (eč'), ...)
 - certain letter-forms if compared to coeval handwritten variants
- all those letters without Greek correspondents are likely an 'inspired' invention of Mesrop Maštoc'
- other connections (Ge'ez, Pahlavi) have been claimed but not substantiated

Gk.	α	β	γ	δ	ε	ζ	η	θ	ι	κ	λ	μ	ν	ξ	ο	π	ρ	σ	τ	υ	φ	χ	ψ	ω												
Arm.	ա	բ	գ	դ	ե	զ	է	թ	ժ	ի	լ	խ	ծ	կ	հ	յ	ն	շ	ո	պ	գ	ւ	փ	ք												
	a	b	g	d	e	z	ē	ə	t'	ž	i	l	x	c	k	h	j	l	č	m	y	n	š	o	č'	p	j	ř	s	v	t	r	c'	w	p'	k'

The Alphabet VI

- the Armenian uncial forms must be compared to Greek minuscules of the same time period, which often only bear faint resemblance to our notion of Greek letters



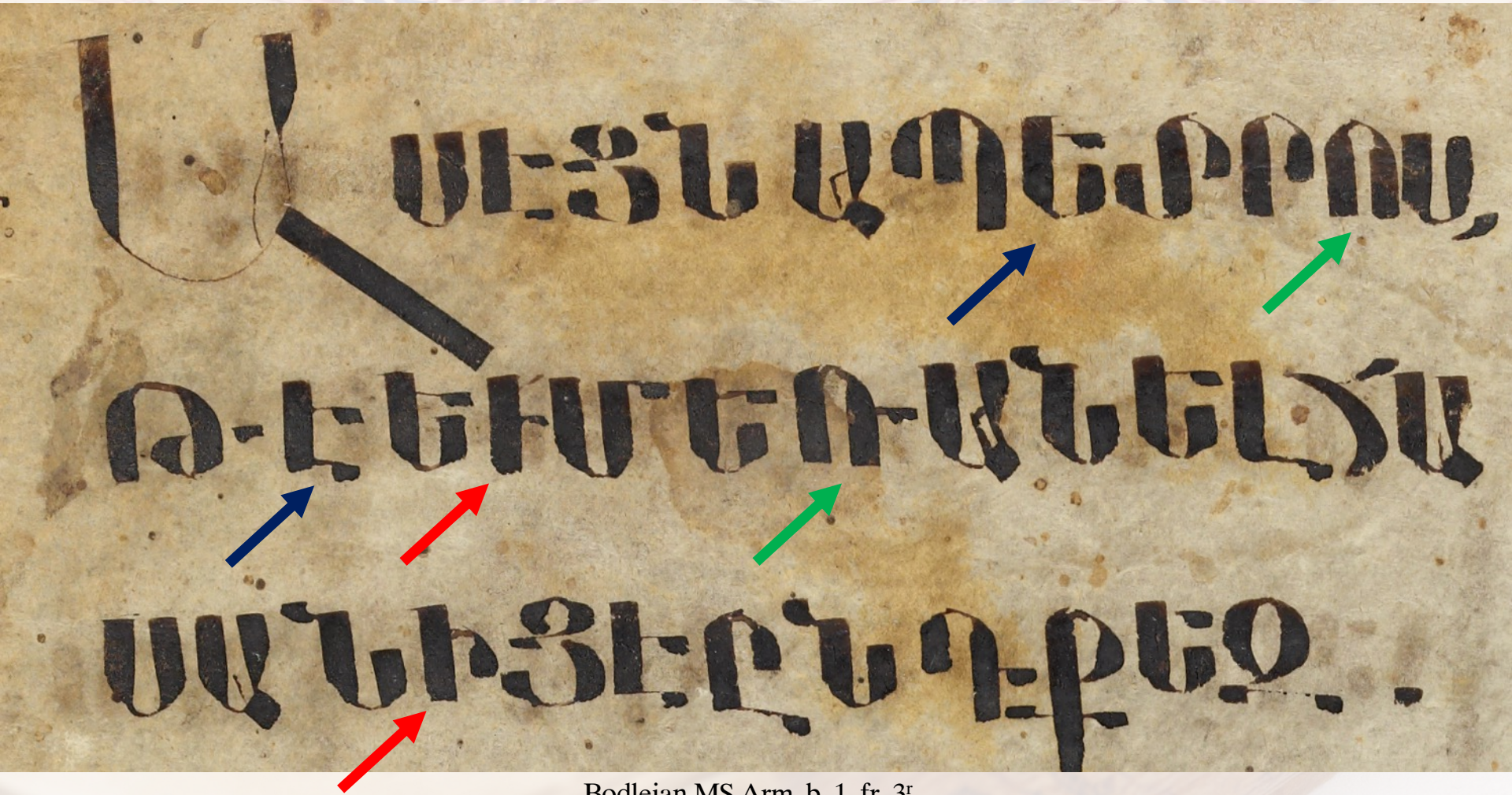
Writing Styles I

- over the centuries, a number of different styles of the alphabet came into and fell out of use
- the main types are as follows:
 - *երկաթագիր* (erkat'agir) – 'iron script', from 5th c., still in epigraphy
 - *բոլորգիր* (bolorgir) – 'round script', from 10th c., basis for print
 - *նօտրգիր* (nōtrgir) – 'notary script', from 16th c., sometimes use as printed cursive
 - *չղագիր* (šlagir) – 'slanted script', modern cursive
- also, there are various ornamental styles:
 - *թռչնագիր* (t'řč'nagir) – 'bird script'
 - *ձկագիր* (jkagir) – 'fish script'
 - *մարդագիր* (mardagir) – 'man script'
- these are used, e.g., for decorative rubrics or headlines

Writing Styles II – *երկաթագիր* (erkat‘agir)

Asē c‘na Petros, t‘ē ew meranel hasanic‘ē and k‘ez

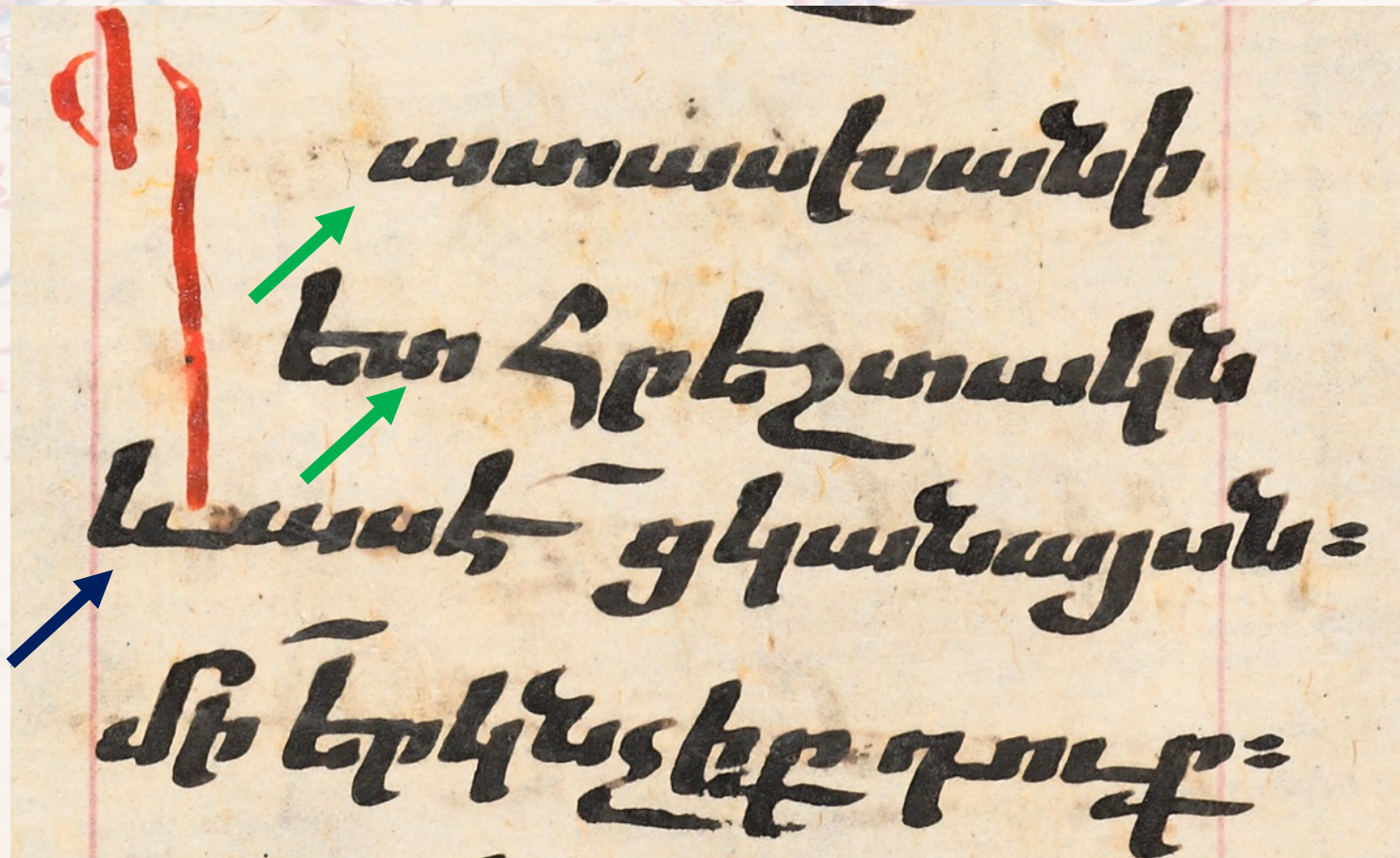
‘Peter said unto him: Though I should die with thee, ...’ (Mt. 26:35)



Writing Styles III – ԲՈԼՈՐԳԻՐ (bolorgir)

Patasxani et hreštakn ew asé c'kanaysn. mí erkñč'ik' duk'

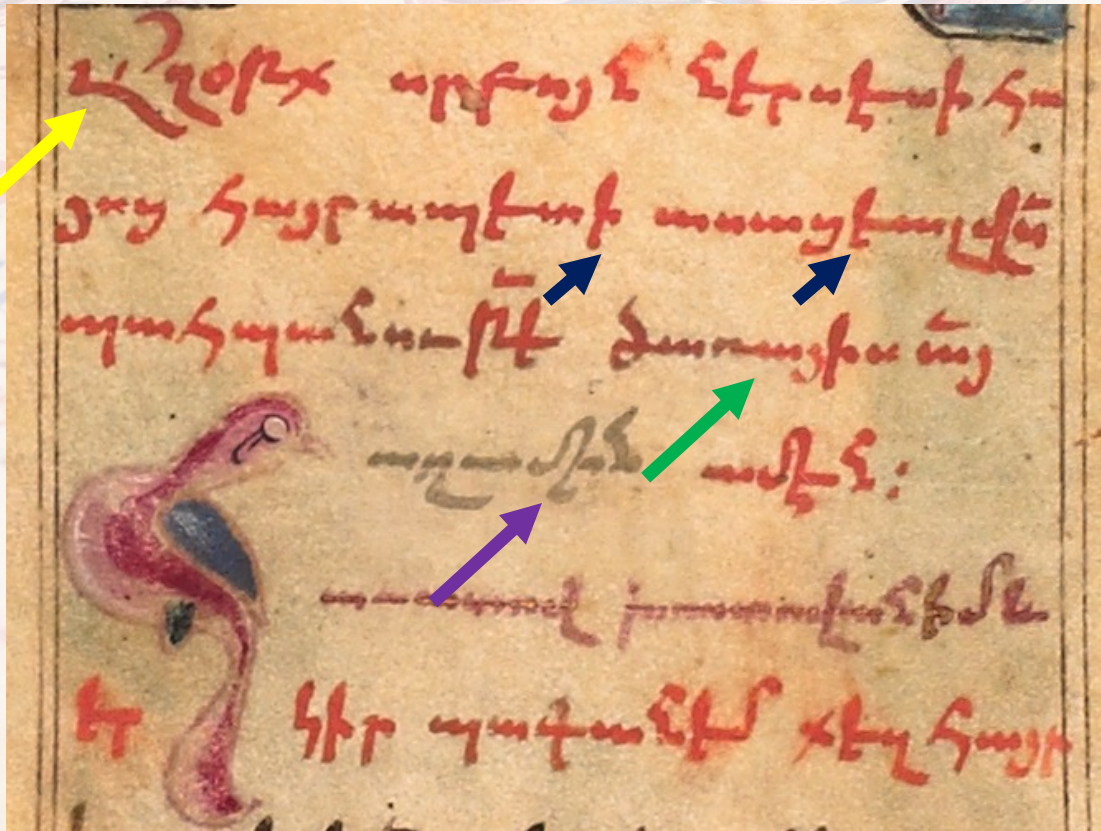
‘And the angel answered and said to the women: Be not afraid .’ (Mt. 28:5)



Writing Styles IV – նօտրգիր (nōtrgir)

*Ałōt‘k‘ srboyn nersēsi hayoc hayrapeti asac‘eal v[a]š[n] pahpahut‘e[an]
caṙayis ā[stuco]y ałamin amēn*

‘Prayers of the Armenian patriarch St Nersēs’ [Šnorhali] said on behalf of
the safety of this here servant of God, Ałam. Amen.



Writing Styles V – շղագիր (šlagir)

[illegible]

Writing Styles VI – Թռչնագիր (t'rc'nagir)

- ornamental forms of writing frequently used as headlines, rubrics, or drop caps
- frequently followed, at the beginning of chapters, by one or more line of uncial script



Writing Styles VI – Թռչնագիր (t‘rč‘nagir)

K‘ERAK^A

NUT‘I[WN] Ē HMTUTIWN

‘Grammar is the skill [...]’ (Dionysios Thrax, *The Art of Grammar*, §1)



Writing Styles VII – մարդագիր (mardagir)



Bodleian MS Arm. d. 25, fol. 158^r (left) and fol. 17^r (right).

Writing Styles VII – մարդագիր (mardagir)

GIRK' CNN || {N}DEAN YĪ K'Ī ORDWOY[N] DAW || T'Ī



Digital Tools I – Calfa

- DH project led by Chahan Vidal-Gorène & Agnès Ouzounian (Paris)
- neural-network based OCR of Armenian mss in the BnF and Matenadaran (Yerevan)
- preservation and accessibility of Armenian mss across institutions
- www.calfa.fr



Digital Tools I – Calfa

Comparison of majuscule ayb (Ա) across manuscripts

CALFA

AboutBlogVision▼Robin Meyer▼OCR Calfa : our projectenglish▼

hy | en ▼Search an English or Armenian word  

Caractères

Document

Manuscrit ▼

Label

ա ▼

Lettercase

Majuscule ▼

Type

Tous ▼

Book

Tous ▼

Date de début

Date de fin

Trier par

Aucun ▼

Actualiser



Digital Tools II – MACaP

- “Manual of Armenian Codicology and Palaeography” in collaboration with Dr Emilio Bonfiglio (Boğaziçi Üniversitesi)
- intended as a digital teaching tool for students and scholars working on / with Armenian mss
- answers the need for instruction in this subject in absence of physical teaching provision
- 2016 pilot funding from the Andrew W. Mellon Foundation
- digitisation of c. 100 mss folia (different times, genres, specifications)
- working with IIIF compatible images and in a dynamic user interface
- currently in proof-of-concept stage, funding applications in development



Thank you!

Շատ շնորհակալություն

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